

ITEM WISE EDITORIAL ... 10th June, 2019



AMERICA FIRST POLICY ... NEW GEO-POLITICAL FORMATIONS



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... DISCUSSION

10th JUNE, 2019

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St. Petersburg consensus

Russia and China are strengthening ties amid tensions with the U.S.

The bonhomie between China's and Russia's leaders at the St. Petersburg International Economic Forum last week was demonstrable. In a sign of the heightened tensions between the U.S. and the two countries, Russia's annual investment gathering was boycotted by the U.S. Ambassador to Russia, Jon Huntsman. His absence was ascribed to the prevailing environment in Russia for foreign entrepreneurs, typified by the detention of U.S. private equity investor Michael Calvey on allegations of fraud. Conversely, the Chinese telecommunications equipment manufacturer Huawei signed an agreement with Russia's principal mobile operator to start 5G networks, in a rebuff to Washington's attempts to isolate the firm internationally. Russian President Vladimir Putin and his Chinese counterpart Xi Jinping made it clear in St. Petersburg that the tensions with the West had only drawn them closer. The rift with Russia began with Moscow's annexation of Crimea in 2014 and the stand-off in eastern Ukraine that continues. Russia's tensions with the U.S. and some EU countries stem also from their opposition to the 1,200-km-long Nord Stream 2 gas pipeline from Russia to Germany. U.S. objections draw in part from its eagerness to export liquefied natural gas to Europe, besides thwarting Moscow's ambition to dominate the region's energy market. Far more sensitive has been U.S. Special Counsel Robert Mueller's inquiry into possible Russian meddling in the 2016 U.S. presidential election. Washington's blacklisting of Huawei, prohibiting it from selling technology to the U.S. and barring domestic firms from supplying semiconductors to Beijing, falls into a class of its own among international trade disputes.

Amid these tensions, in St. Petersburg Mr. Xi and Mr. Putin emphasised that bilateral relations were at a historic high, marked by increased diplomatic and strategic cooperation. China participated in Russian military exercises on its eastern border last September, marking a watershed. Moscow and Beijing, hostile rivals of the Cold War era, have for a while been adopting common positions at the UN Security Council on critical international issues. Bilateral relations are also guided by pragmatism. Russia appears realistic about the growing Chinese economic clout in Central Asia, once firmly in its sphere of influence, thanks to China's massive infrastructure investments under the Belt and Road Initiative. Chinese cooperation would moreover prove critical for Russia's elaborate plans to exploit the Northern Sea Route along the Arctic as an alternative transportation hub. International sanctions have not been very effective in isolating Russia. European states, notably Germany, recognise the importance of engaging with Russia to contain Mr. Putin's expansionist aims. Equally, President Donald Trump's "America first" policy is compelling potential rivals to make common cause.

THE HINDU
INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1816

10th June, 2019

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations

Effect of policies and politics of developed and developing countries on India's interests, Indian diaspora.

DRAFT QUESTION

USA's "America First Policy" with abandonment of several international agreements is giving rise to new geopolitical formations. Discuss.

OR

President Donald Trump's "America First Policy" is compelling potential rivals to make common cause. Critically examine.



2 St. Petersburg consensus

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USA & ITS RELATIONS WITH RUSSIA AND CHINA

Barents Sea

- CAATSA law can impose sanctions on Russian firms.
- U.S. Special Counsel Robert Mueller's inquiry into possible Russian meddling in the 2016 U.S. presidential election further strained the relations.
- There are already sanctions imposed on Russia by several western countries.
- Recently, U.S. private equity investor was detained by Russia on allegations of fraud.

RUSSIA



- Tariffs and counter tariffs are going on between USA and China.
- USA blacklisted Huawei, prohibiting it from selling technology to the U.S..
- It also barred domestic firms from supplying semiconductors to Beijing.

CHINA



North
Pacific
Ocean



CHINA - RUSSIA BONHOMIE

- Chinese telecom equipment manufacturer, Huawei signed an agreement with Russia's principal mobile operator to start 5G networks.
- It is quite contrary to the U.S. attempt to isolate the firm internationally.
- China participated in Russian military exercises on its eastern border last September.
- On critical international issues, they are adopting common positions at the UN Security Council.



Russia appears realistic about the growing Chinese economic clout in Central Asia. China is investing heavily in the Belt and Road Initiative.

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